tralia. Suddenly, everyone started talking about the Kashmir willow. Ever since, some 150,000 bats from J&K have been exported to almost all the cricket-playing nations. It also made its IPL debut this year with Afghan cricketer Fazal Haq Farooqi of the Sunrisers Hyderabad using a KIS bat—again manufactured by a unit in Halmulla—to good effect.

This success has come the hard way for Kabeer. "My family sold 26 kanals of land to fund my travels for research. The year 2013 was tumultuous, I was distraught after my dad passed away, even on the verge of suicide as the company was in crisis. But that year, I also reached the ICC cricket academy in Dubai and got technical inputs from them about bat manufacturing," says Kabeer, who is currently a PhD scholar in strategic management at Dublin City University, Ireland.

Back home, he got skilled workers from Jalandhar and Meerut and the unit soon started producing bats that met international standards. Still, no international team was ready to take risks and use Kabeer's bats. The breakthrough came after the ICC gave the nod to GR8 bats in April 2021.

A LONG HISTORY

The bat manufacturing industry is over 100 years old in the Valley. The cleft is sourced from the *Salix alba* 'Caerulea', the female variant of the willow tree that grows in marshy lands. In Kashmir, the willow was valued primarily for fodder and fuel, according to British settlement commissioner Walter Lawrence's 1885 book, *The Valley of Kashmir*. He suggested that a Kashmiri be sent to England to learn the art of basket-weaving and bat-making. "The *vir* or willow grows in every village of Kashmir where there is water or moisture and its reproduction is very simple. There is an enormous waste of withies every year, as the young wands are cut down for fodder and...fuel," he wrote while documenting the flora of the Valley. "There is ample material in the valley to supply the whole of India with excellent baskets and chair."

A 2014 paper by the Sher-e-Kashmir University of Agricultural Sciences and Technology of Kashmir (SKUAST) says Allah Baksh, a resident of Sialkot (now in Pakistan), set up the first bat manufacturing unit in Halmulla in the 1920s. After Partition, several manufacturers from Sialkot shifted to Meerut in Uttar Pradesh and Jalandhar in Punjab, sourcing the wood from Kashmir and selling bats under their own labels. That continued till the J&K government declared a ban on the export of clefts in 1998 to arrest the wholesale felling of trees. But illegal transport of clefts continued.

Javid Ahmad Parray, 42, who owns a bat unit in Chursoo village in Awantipora, says he started his business in 2000 with a mere Rs 25,000. Today, his unit manufactures some 200 bats a day. "In the first four years, I was sending semi-finished bats to Meerut and Jalandhar to earn quick money. They would use their brands on bats and change the handles," he says at the retail shop in front of his factory. Stacks of cleft lie outside drying in the sun. "Now we make bats for both leather and tennis ball cricket (the latter are made of lower quality willow)," he says. Spread over a few villages in Pulwama and neighbouring Anantnag, there are now some 400 units making bats and cricket accessories in the Valley.

₹1.25 lakh
AVG. PRICE OF AN ENGLISH WILLOW BAT

₹10,000
AVG. PRICE OF A KASHMIR WILLOW BAT

3 million
NO. OF BATS PRODUCED IN J&K BAT UNITS ANNUALLY

150,000
ESTIMATED NO. OF J&K BATS EXPORTED SINCE 2022

5 million
ESTIMATED NO. OF WILLOW TREES LEFT IN KASHMIR



SHRINKING WILLOW

But just as the Kashmir willow begins to hold its own against its English cousin, the shrinking number of willow trees threatens to uproot that hard-earned recognition. Rampant felling in the past, the lack of new plantations and the fact that farmers no longer want to plant willow on their land (they much prefer the poplars that offer better returns in less time) have all played a part. Indeed, when the Cricket Bat Manufacturing Association (CBMA) of Kashmir met Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on May 24 to sort out their grievances, the shortage of raw material topped the list. They wanted the state to plant willow saplings developed at the SKUAST labs on public land, wetlands and embankments to prevent the collapse of the industry.

CBMA president Fayaz Ahmad Dar says a crisis is imminent—they may have to shutter their units in five years if the willow shortage persists. The industry is worth Rs 300 crore a year today, employs over 100,000 people directly or indirectly, but also needs 200,000 trees to produce three million new bats every year. "Since the international recognition, the demand for